Duolingo × Taco Bell

Duo Has a *Date* at Taco Bell

A playful, unserious push to try the Duo Habanero, launching 10/6.

Cindy Ha · AI in Marketing · Assignment 4



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A. VISUAL BRIEF

Duo is Never Nervous on a First Date

REFERENCES

Duo at the Taco Bell counter: a physical Duo shot like a real employee in an unglamorous fast-food setting [left]



Duo Habanero flat lay: the product and a Duolingo lesson in one frame, green packets popping against wrappers [right]

IDEA

Duo is never nervous on a first date. He'll take you to Taco Bell with zero shame just to try the new Duo Habanero, and he'll make you pay.

SUBJECT & COMPOSITION

Duo mascot in real Taco Bell settings, outfits by scene (work lanyard, brown suit). The date: pink bow, pink dress, deadpan. Low angles and 0.5x wide lens so Duo fills the frame.

LIGHT & COLOR

Duolingo green leads, Taco Bell purple supports, pink and orange as accents. Harsh on-camera flash, warm fluorescent interiors.

MEDIUM & ERA

Photoreal mascot, 2026 phone camera for social, retro film for formal ads. Bad 2000s infomercial staging and expressions.

ANTI-BRIEF

Duolingo never takes the safe route. If it could run for any brand, it fails.

- Generic, boring, or overly polished content
- Let any color outweigh Leaf Green
- Overly realistic or human features on Duo: no fingers



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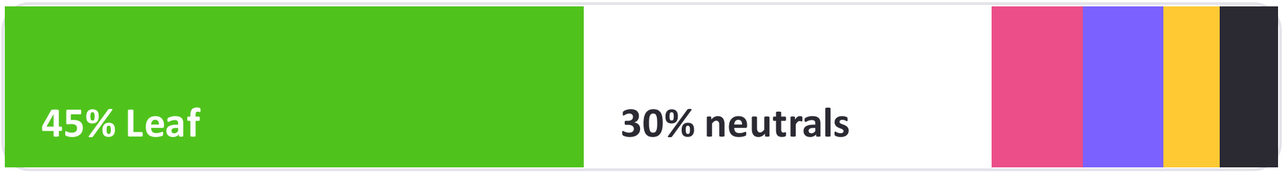
B. MOOD BOARD

The Realness is the Joke



C. DESIGN SYSTEM · COLOR + TYPE

Green Leads, Everyone Else is an Accent



Leaf · #4FC31C

Berry · #EC4E8A

Grape · #7B61FF

Sunny · #FFC933

Ink · #2B2A33

PARTNER EXCEPTION

Taco Bell purple may fill partner-space backgrounds. It never counts as an accent.



Title 96

Headline 56

Subhead · Nunito 800 · 32

Body · Nunito 600 · 24

Caption · Nunito 600 · 18

LABEL · NUNITO 900 · 14

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C. DESIGN SYSTEM · LAYOUT, IMAGERY, COMPONENTS

One System, From Deck to 24x36 Poster

Spacing & layout

8px base unit: every margin and gap is a multiple of 8

Deck (16:9): 96px side margins, 80px top and bottom, 12-column grid, 48px between blocks, headline top-left

Poster (2:3): 1.5in margins, 0.125in bleed. Headline in the top third, hero in the middle, offer at the bottom

Social: 64px clear; stories keep top 250 and bottom 400 free

Imagery

2D: flat vector, solid fills, delivered as editable SVG

Treatment by channel: retro film (light grain, warm cast) for formal ads, 2026 phone camera with harsh flash and 0.5x lens for social.

Palette: green leads, partner color supports

Subject matter: everyday moments (drive thrus, first dates, etc.)

Components

Section header: small caps label in a green pill, headline below

Card: white, 2px border, rounded corners, optional ledge shadow

Stat callout: big green number in Baloo, short label underneath

Quote block: speech bubble with a ledge; social quotes stay lowercase

Image frame: rounded corners, ledge shadow, caption below

Starburst: orange or pink, one per layout max

Meme caption: white text with a dark outline, social only

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C. DESIGN SYSTEM · RULES

Fourteen Things Duo Never Does

1. Let any color outweigh leaf green
2. Use more than 3 accents, or pastel tints
3. Use pure black, sharp corners or gradients
4. Use stock photos
5. Use fluency clichés: grad caps, flags, certificates
6. Look expensive or overly polished
7. Draw the mascot off-model
8. Shame the learner
9. Center body copy
10. Use more than one starburst
11. Flatten text into images
12. Comment on politics, religion or tragedy
13. Translate a joke word for word
14. Jump on a dead trend

CULTURAL RELEVANCE

Jump on trends, celeb moments and brand drama within 24 to 48 hours, or skip. Never politics, religion or tragedy.

INTERNATIONAL

Mascot, Leaf and layout stay global. Copy, jokes, dates and offers are written natively per market.

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D. KEY VISUAL 1A

Duo can be spotted at Taco Bell before work, during work, and after work.

FINAL PROMPT

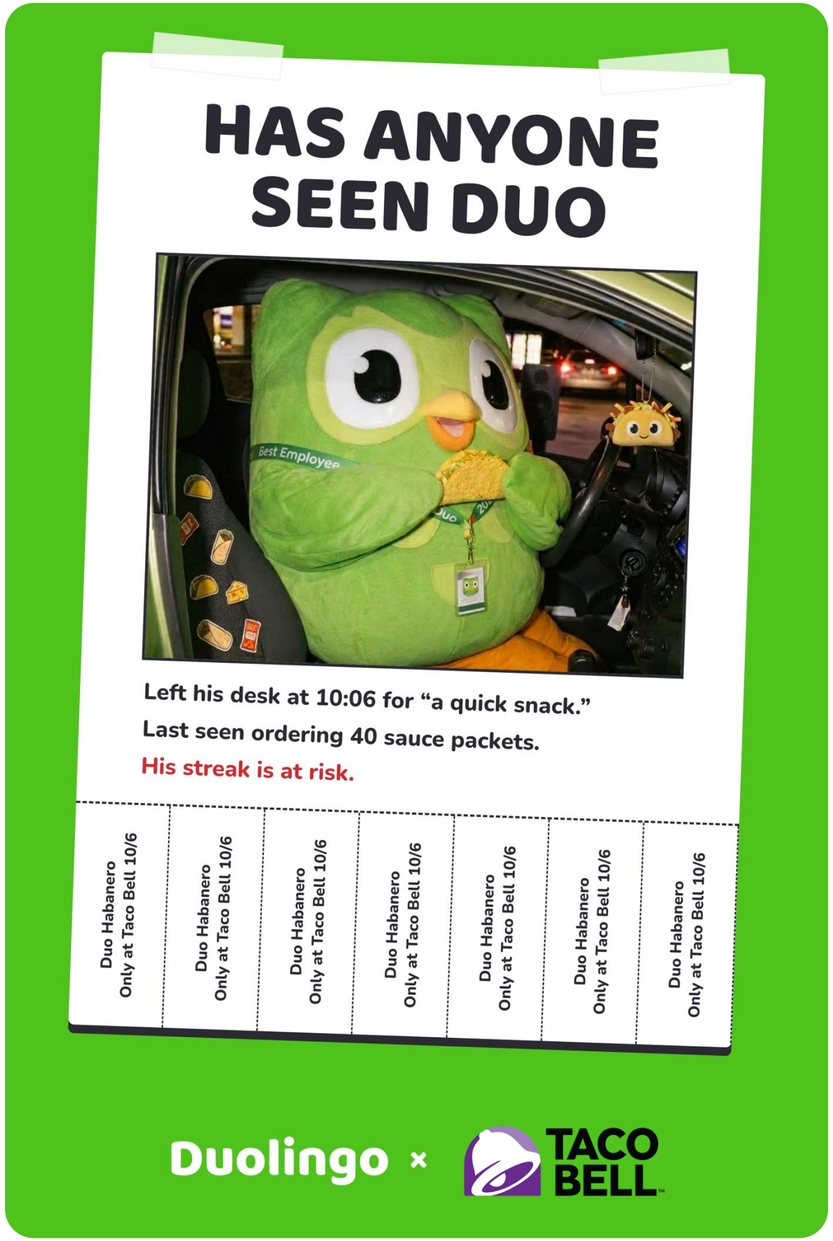
"[Duo base], wearing a white button-up work shirt and a green employee lanyard, sitting in the driver's seat of a small, beat-up hatchback in a Taco Bell drive-thru at night. Devouring a grilled cheese burrito with both wings, dozens of green hot sauce packets all over the dashboard, seats, and his lap. Shot through the open driver's window, slightly low angle, wide lens. Harsh on-camera flash, purple drive-thru glow in the background, lime green dominant. 35mm film photo, light grain, warm cast, candid and slightly crooked, like a found photo. No readable text. 2:3 aspect ratio.

EDITS IN GEMINI

1. "This leans a bit disgusting and unappetizing. Make it look sillier and cuter."
2. "The white shirt is giving hospital patient. Maybe just a lanyard is fine."
3. "Make the sticker decals look more realistic. Add a cute and silly charm to the photo."
4. "Update the lanyard text to say: 'Best Employee' and have the charm hanging smile instead of frown. Do not change up the eyes."

Duo in his work lanyard, eating a taco in a parked car, makes Taco Bell feel like part of his daily routine, with zero shame. The harsh flash, sticker-covered seat and hanging taco charm give it the unpolished, found-photo realness the brief asks for. Leaf green fills the frame while Taco Bell purple only glows in the background, so it could not run for any other brand.

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D. KEY VISUAL 1B

Has anyone seen Duo? Last spotted spotted ordering 40 sauce packets. packets.

FINAL PROMPT (CLAUDE DESIGN)

"Use the Zuzu Design System and the existing Lost poster template. Format: 2:3 vertical, 24x36 in, 1.5 in margins, 0.125 in bleed. Photo: Duo in his car at the Taco Bell drive-thru (Key Visual 1a), cropped from just above the car door frame to just below the packet heart. Keep the harsh flash as-is. Leaf green leads the paper or frame; the photo carries the purple. Header: HAS ANYONE SEEN DUO. Copy: Left his desk at 10:06 for 'a quick snack.' Last seen ordering 40 sauce packets. His streak is at risk. Tear-off tabs (6 to 8): Duo Habanero · Only at Taco Bell 10/6. Duolingo × Taco Bell lockup at the bottom. Feel: scrappy, slightly crooked, like it was taped to a pole."

NOTES

1. Built in Claude Design using the photo from Key Visual 1a, not generated in Gemini.
2. Asked for two copy versions (Missing pet and Concerned coworker) and picked Concerned coworker.

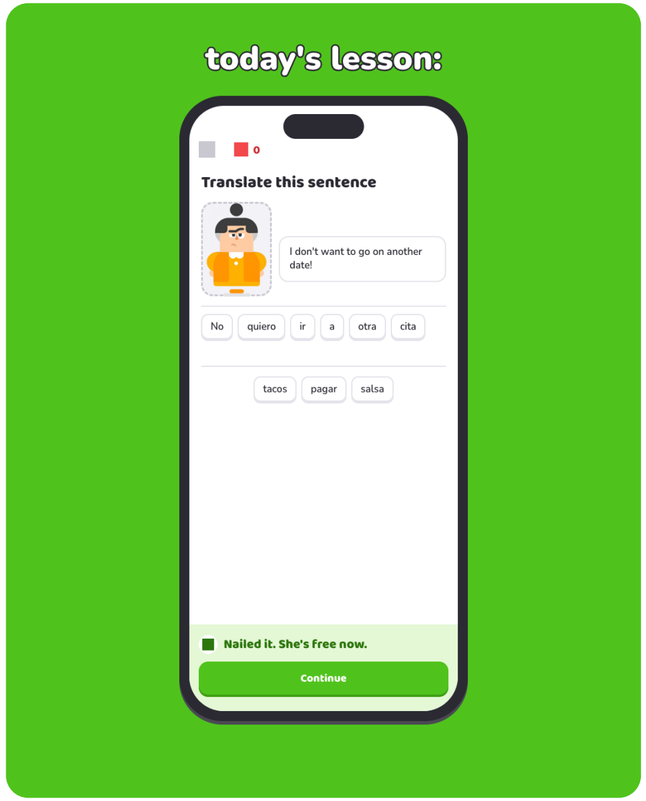
Everyone knows the missing-pet flyer, so the joke lands in a second: Duo did not go missing, he just went to Taco Bell. The tear-off tabs turn the 10/6 launch into something people literally take with them, and “His streak is at risk” borrows Duolingo’s famous guilt trip without shaming the learner. Leaf green owns the poster and the deadpan copy keeps it unserious.

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D. KEY VISUAL 2

Every bad date ends in a lesson.





FINAL PROMPT

"Using the reference image, create a scene from the female bird's POV that details the following: Duo is standing up and half-turned toward the exit, cheerfully waving goodbye with one wing while his other wing slides a receipt across the table toward the camera. A big pile of torn, empty green hot sauce packets and burrito wrappers left on his side of the table. Wide-open eyes, cheerful, oblivious. Eye-level, wide lens, 4:5 vertical. Harsh on-camera flash, background purple softly out of focus, lime green dominant. 2026 phone camera photo, candid, slightly motion-blurred wing, crooked framing. No stickers or decals, no readable text anywhere."

EDITS IN GEMINI

1. "He should be sliding the receipt to her, not holding it like he's about to pay."
2. "Have the receipt closer and crumpled to her."
3. "Fix the bird's fingers (he shouldn't have any). Make it rounded like the bird on the left corner. Make it look like she has paid, with her wallet and card on the table as he waves goodbye."
4. "Edit the picture so there is only 1 receipt on the table and make the wallet more girly and cute."

Slide 2 (lesson screen) was built in Claude Design with the Zuzu lesson UI kit, not Gemini.

The date photo puts the viewer in her seat while Duo waves next to a PAID receipt and her pink wallet, so the punchline needs no caption. Pairing it with a lesson slide turns the bad date into an actual translation exercise and ties the campaign back to the app. It follows the two-character rule from the drift check, with green leading and pink as the main accent.

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E. DRIFT CHECK

The vague rules broke first, so I made them specific.

FLATTENED **The bouquet poster**



RULE THAT BROKE

“Green leads.” Purple took over the whole poster, and Gemini even swapped in Taco Bell’s own red sauce packets.

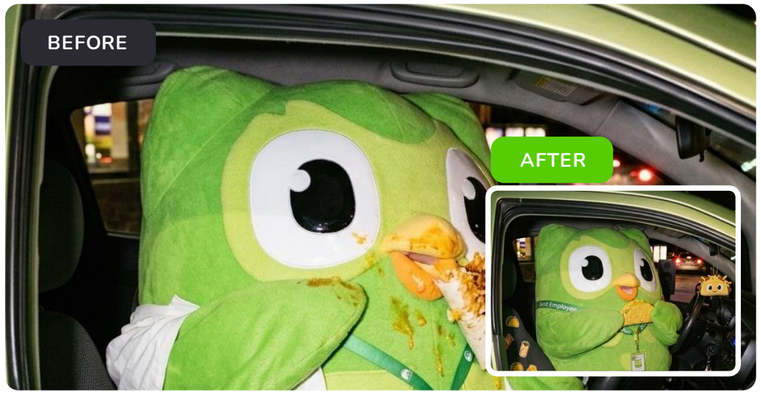
WHAT A VIEWER SEES

A Taco Bell ad. Nothing says Duolingo.

NEW RULE

“In partner-owned spaces, the partner color may lead the background. The product and mascot stay green.”

DRIFTED **Duo himself**



RULE THAT BROKE

“Never draw the mascot off-model.” Too vague for Gemini to check, so Duo came back messy, sleepy, and with fingers.

WHAT A VIEWER SEES

Not “off-brand,” just gross or a little creepy.

NEW RULES

“Eyes wide open.” “Rounded wings, no fingers.” “Greedy, never gross.”

DRIFTED **Two-character scenes**



RULE THAT BROKE

“The date is always seen from behind.” Gemini kept turning both faces toward the camera.

WHAT A VIEWER SEES

Duo on a date with his clone.

NEW RULE

“Only one face goes to camera. In two-character scenes, the other is shot from behind.”

BLIND TEST My partner instantly recognized it as Duolingo, no name needed. Duolingo is just too iconic!

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APPENDIX

Rejected Generations



Too gross: sauce on his face, and the white shirt read like a hospital gown, not a work outfit.



Cuter, but too clean. Without the stickers and charm, the car lost its personality. Preferred the look of hard-shell tacos over burrito.



Close, but two lanyards showed up.

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APPENDIX

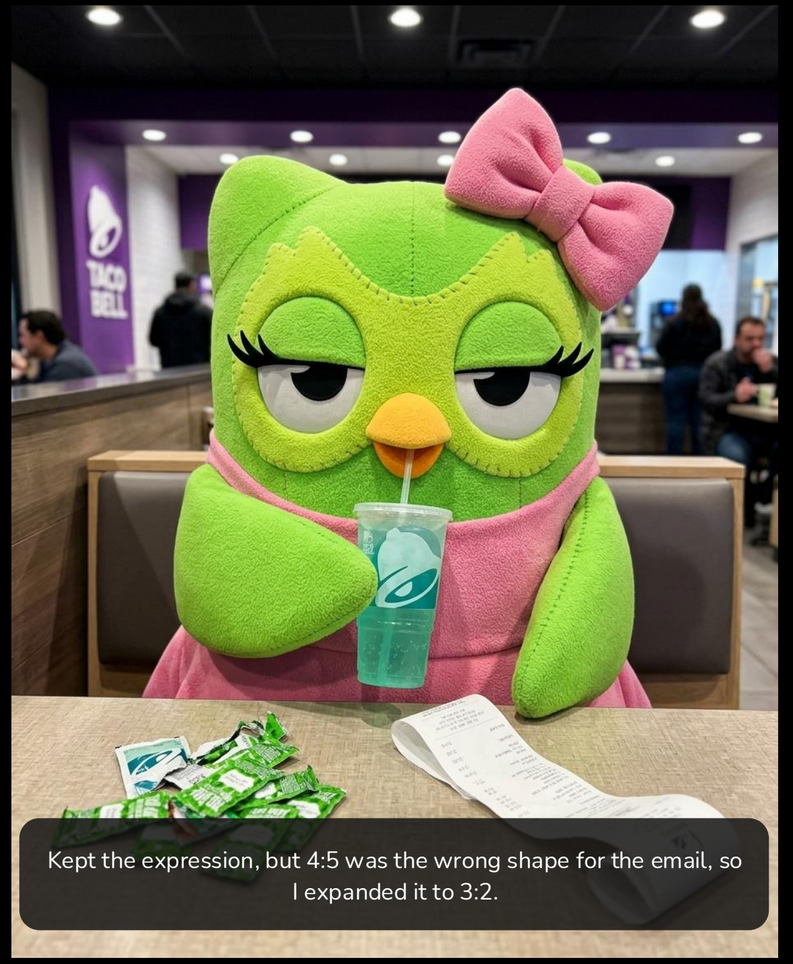
Rejected Generations



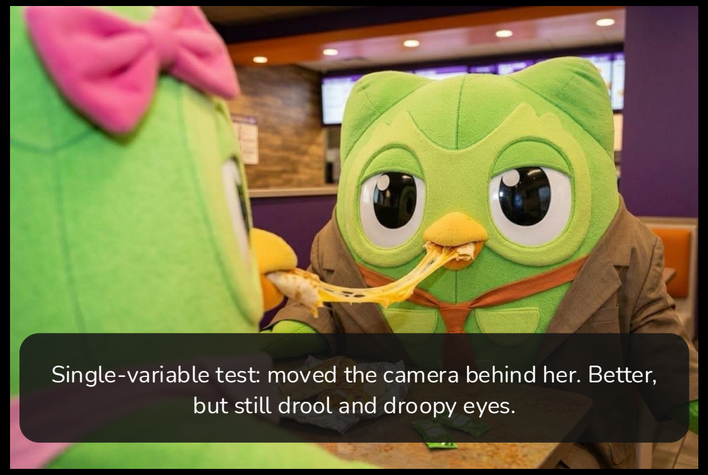
Round 1: green pupils, and the cheese stretched beak to beak with no burrito attached.



Two identical faces made it look like Duo was on a date with his clone.



Kept the expression, but 4:5 was the wrong shape for the email, so I expanded it to 3:2.



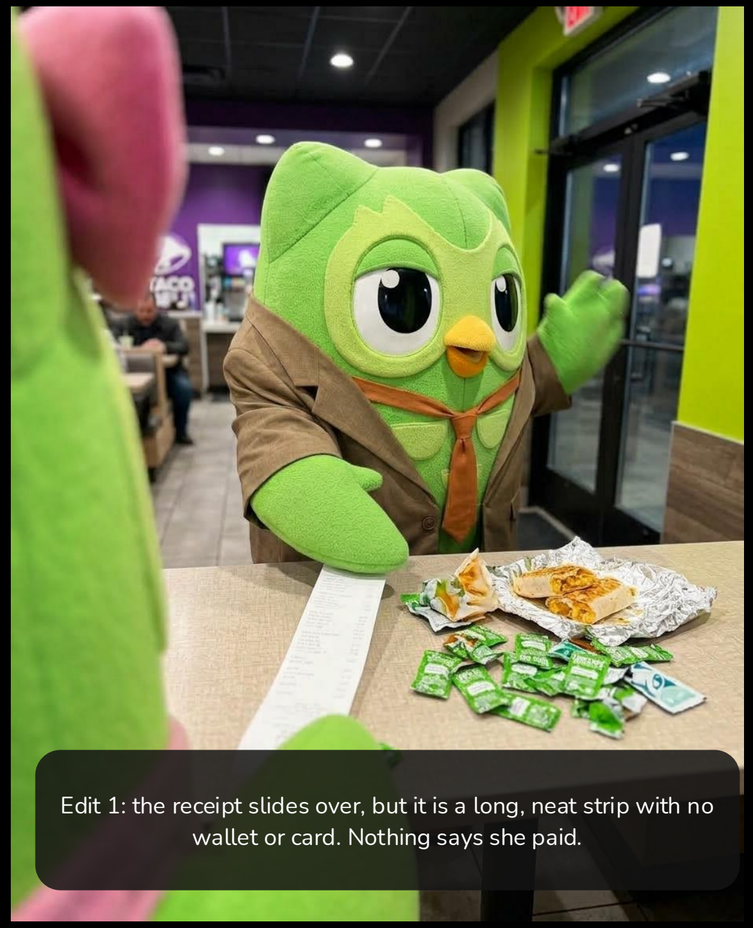
Single-variable test: moved the camera behind her. Better, but still drool and droopy eyes.



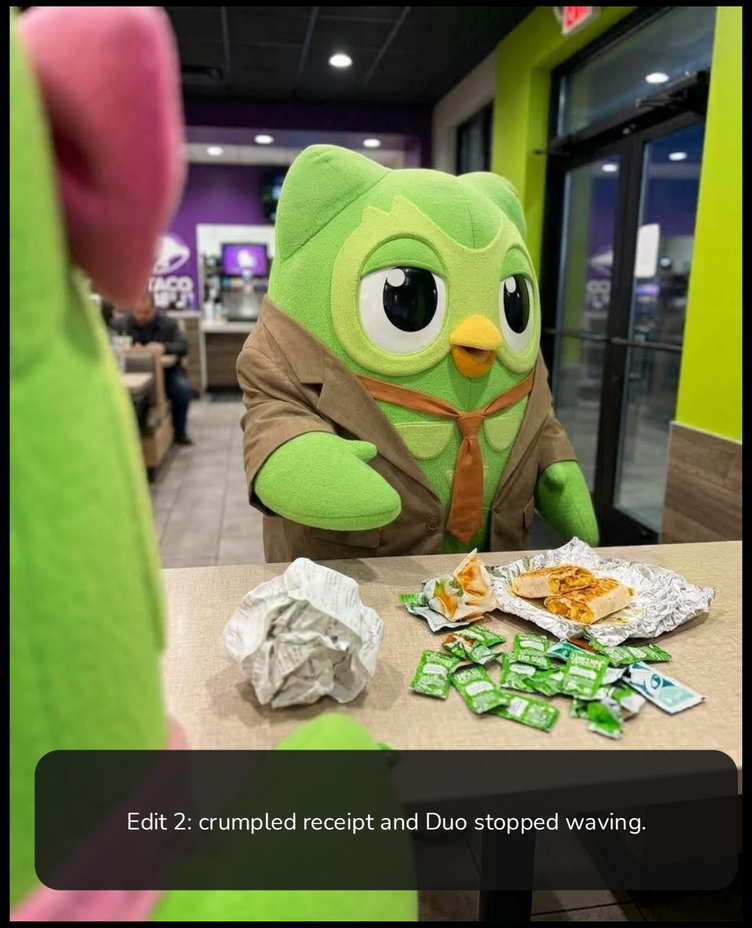
Staging was still awkward. Random lamp added that did not blend in.

APPENDIX

Rejected Generations



Edit 1: the receipt slides over, but it is a long, neat strip with no wallet or card. Nothing says she paid.



Edit 2: crumpled receipt and Duo stopped waving.



Edit 3: wallet and card added, but two PAID receipts showed up and the wallet was plain, not girly.

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APPENDIX

Rejected Generations



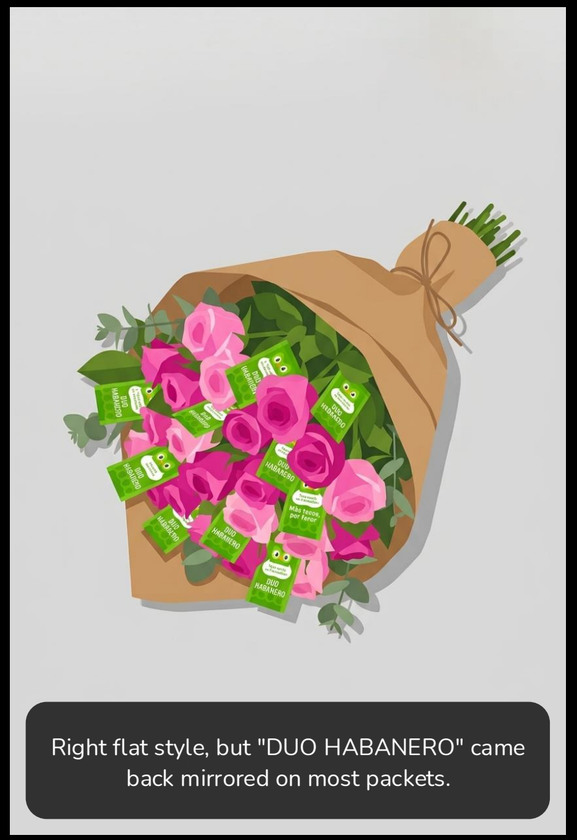
Photoreal on purple. Reads like a Taco Bell ad, not a collab.

Gemini's full poster: generic font, purple everywhere, nothing that says Duolingo.





Isolated for Claude Design, but the photoreal look still felt obviously AI.



Right flat style, but "DUO HABANERO" came back mirrored on most packets.

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Bonus: The Date-Aftermath Email

WHY IT'S HERE

This email didn't make my final key visuals, but it shows Zuzu working in a third channel. The date's side-eye does the storytelling, so the email only needs one headline and one button.

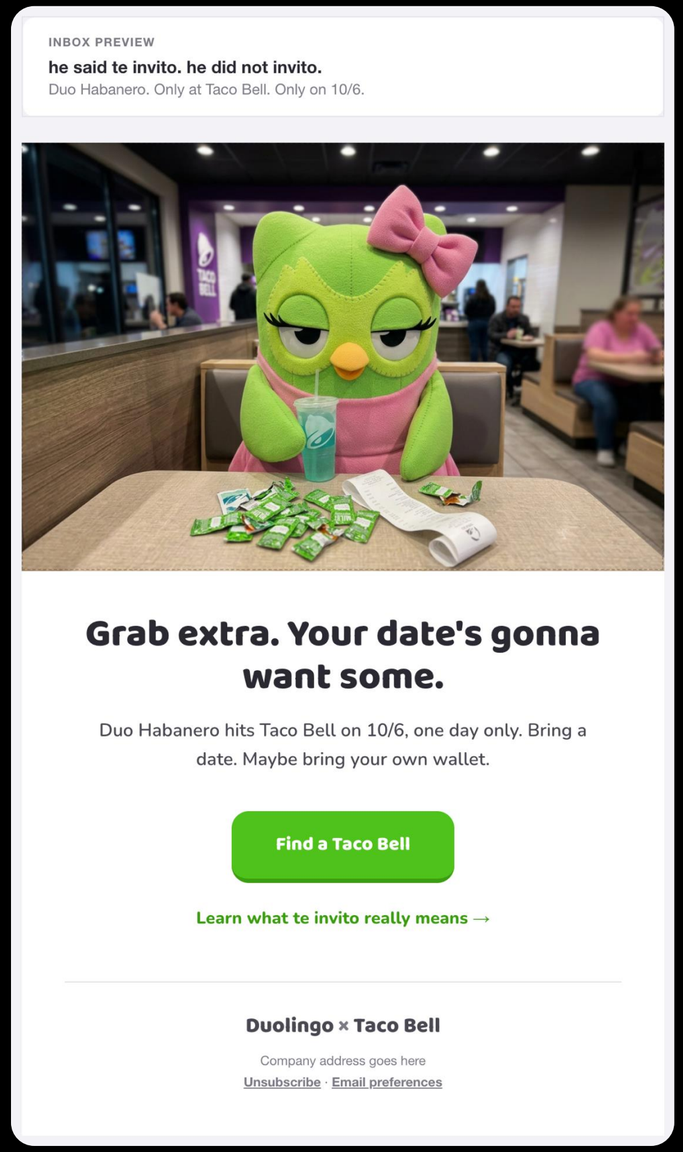
WHAT'S IN IT

Subject: he said te invito. he did not invito.

Headline: Grab extra. Your date's gonna want some.

CTA: Find a Taco Bell

All copy is live text, so it still shows if images are blocked.



APPENDIX

Sources and AI Disclosure

Gemini

- Generated all campaign photos and illustrations.

Claude

- Copywriting support and voice checks (/duolingo-copywriter).
- Models used: Opus 5.5 & Sonnet 5.5

Claude Design

- Zuzu design system, templates and asset layouts.

Canva

- Manually built and annotated the mood board.

IMAGE SOURCES

TITLE SLIDE

Duo Habanero packets: "Duo is clocking in at Taco Bell" post, Instagram, 2026. instagram.com/p/Dd_phTfhysf
Duo illustration: WTAE, "Pittsburgh-based company Duolingo revives mascot following 'death'," 2025
Taco Bell logo: "The Evolution & History of the Taco Bell's Iconic Logo"
Paint splatter: "White Paint Splatter PNGs for Free Download," free PNG library

A. VISUAL BRIEF

Reference 1, Duo at the counter: "Duo is clocking in at Taco Bell" post, Instagram, 2026. instagram.com/p/Dd_phTfhysf
Reference 2, Duo Habanero flat lay: Taco Bell Newsroom, "Taco Bell and Duolingo Take National Taco Day Global," 2026. tacobell.com/newsroom/taco-bell-and-duolingo-take-national-taco-day-global
Duo in the anti-brief: "Duolingo Owl," Super Smash Bros. Fanon Wiki, Fandom

B. MOOD BOARD

Duo mascot posts (keyboards, "polyglot"): @duolingo, Instagram. instagram.com/duolingo
Duo at the drive-thru window and counter: Taco Bell × Duolingo collab post, Instagram, 2026. instagram.com/p/Dd9RWS5lCAK
Duo illustrations (heart, shy): Duolingo
"Disaster Girl" meme: photo of Zoë Roth by Dave Roth, 2004
Crying cat "Smile?" meme: internet meme, original creator unknown

C. DESIGN SYSTEM AND D. KEY VISUALS

Duo with a heart (color slide): UX Collective on Medium, "I neglected my Duolingo for 20 days after signing up. Here's every email they sent me." uxdesign.cc/i-neglected-my-duolingo-for-20-days-after-signing-up-heres-every-email-they-sent-me-ecd0f32ce2ed
Lesson speaker (Key Visual 2): DuoPlanet, "Duolingo Character Names: The Complete Guide"

APPENDIX

Email layout reference: Page Flows, Duolingo email examples. pageflows.com/emails/product/duolingo

EVERY SLIDE

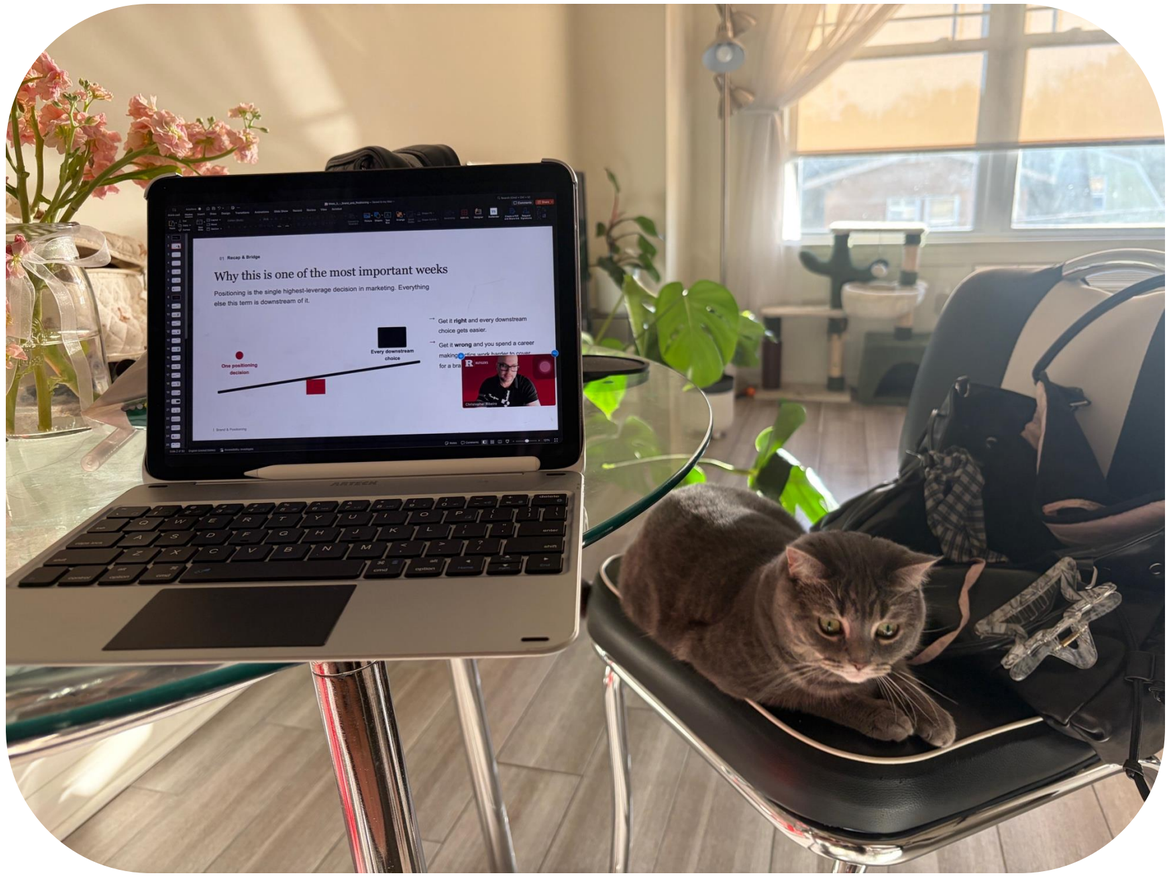
Duolingo logo: Wikimedia Commons, "File:Duolingo logo.svg." commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Duolingo_logo.svg

All other campaign images were generated in Gemini or built in Claude Design (see left).

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Zuzu



Design system inspired by honorary AI in Marketing classmate, Zuzu.



Class in bed. She’s locked in though, don’t worry!

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